

Those darn bells!

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Those darn bells!

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Summary

An action story about an OC team - a Kurama, a Hyuuga and an Inuzuka - which encountered Kakashi's "bell test" way too many times, thus got kinda angsty. Placed in Kakashi's youth, before the original series. No romance.

Notes

Originally posted on FanFiction.net in 2008. Unedited since then, so English and punctuation might be poor in some places.

The evening was still young, so many people were on the streets, enjoying the activities they did, even if it was late fall and it already was dark.

She was walking slowly, gazing on all those pretty things she'd find in the shops and wondering since when Konohagakure no sato became so rich. Was she away for so long? She knew about the Kitsune Kyuubi and his sealing, and the long, long mourning for the Fourth Hokage, but she would never expect the Konoha people to get up from their knees so quickly, rebuilding and even improving the village so much.

There were many Genins, too. Who would think that so many kids would go for being a ninja in their lives, knowing what happens in such a life. And the older ones, probably Chuunins already. Who would tell that they'd survive being a Genin? Who'd tell they become a Chuunin? Even she came out of the Chuunin Exams hardly alive, being carried by her teammates to the tower in the middle of Forest of Death. But she did it, she became a Chuunin. Then, she thought that she would never be able to become a Jounin if becoming a Chuunin was almost beyond her abilities. Now, looking on all those rookies, which don't know what fear and death are, but still proudly wearing the forehead protectors, she wondered if it wouldn't be great, be one of those few from her clan that managed to become a Jounin...

Now, when she's back from the spying mission, already reported what happened in the Land of Water, she's free. She can do anything, until next mission of course. What a relief, being able to take off the mask for more time than taking a quick shower, to breathe normally, to not to fear constantly...

"What shall I do?" she asked herself quietly, looking around for any kind of an activity she'd be keen on. "It's so different now. Different from what I remember and from what I've got used to in Country of Water... People, traditions, places I remember... like here - there was a house here, now it's a ramen bar... I'm not even sure if the K.I.A. memorial stone is where it was..." she pondered. She sighed after a while of standing senselessly in the middle of road and jumped on a roof, going to see if the stone was where she remembered it to be. Plus, it's really better to look at a city from up to know it's ways.

The stone was there, near the training field where her dreams failed. She moulded some chakra and mixed up with the trees before she'd realise what a stupid thing to do that is, hiding like a spy in her own village. She wanted to uncast the camouflage, but after hearing a rumour, she took that thought back. Someone was there too, and she knew that she wasn't ready to talk to any Konoha ninja after several years of absence. Even giving Hokage the report was a pain, knowing she still speaks, walks and acts like a Bloody Mist ninja.

A shinobi came out of the trees near to her, but probably not knowing about her presence. He - or she, it was too dark to see - walked from the forest, heading for the memorial stone. Then the shinobi came into a strand of moonlight, which allowed her to see more details: it was a man, definitely a man. Quite well built, a strong one. His forehead protector was worn crookedly and his hair, very fair hair, probably even white, was almost straight up.

She reprimened herself for seeing everything like a spy, while the shinobi walked up to the stone.

"That way of walking... I've already saw it somewhere..." she whispered to herself. The shinobi twitched and looked around.

"He must have heard me!" she thought, hiding behind a tree trunk, but then she stopped. "I'm such a silly, he's probably also a Konoha... being a spy sure makes you go nuts..."

"Well well, isn't it Kawayui Kurama. Weren't you in the Land of Water? Back already, I see, yet still acting as in constant danger." she heard from her upper right. How could he see her? And how he managed to sneak up to her without any noise, in a twinkling? Must be a Jounin. Definiately a Jounin... And his voice, she already heard it somewhere... He knew her name, he must know her... She looked up, just to see the one who was talking to her.

"Hatake-sensei?!"

She was surprised, so much surprised. And angry. From all shinobi she could've met, she had to bump into Kakashi Hatake, the Copy Ninja. Her old sensei.

"Why so surprised, Kawayui? Who you'd expected to see here? Hokage-sama?"

"I expected no one" she said coldly, turning back. "Was just passing, Hatake-sensei"

"Sure you were. Oh, by the way. You remember how I really don't like being called by my surname? And I'm not your sensei anymore, happily" he sighed, putting his hand on the tree trunk. Kawayui jumped up on an another's tree branch.

"Happily you're not. I'm a Chuunin already, Hatake-sensei" she hissed, while non-stop thinking "A shinobi has no feelings, a shinobi has no feelings... Man, how I hate that old bastard Hatake!"

She started to dash though the trees, heading back to town.

"Yeah. Still not having a good time with your team mates?" He'd jump too, landing just where she was before a second and caught up to her.

"We managed to do the mission fine, Hatake-sensei."

"So, where are they now, anyway?"

"Have to go already, Hatake-sensei" Kawayui, ignoring his question, quickly ran off somewhere, hoping he wouldn't go after her to mock her more. How she hates him...!

"See you soon, Kawayui!"

The night was already kinda old, and she was still walking around Konoha, through forests and cliffs to calm herself down, but it barely gave any effect. Kawayui's anger even became worse, with the silence enhancing her memories...

"... and the last one in this team, Kawayui Kurama. "

The little, fragile-looking girl with curly, red hair looked around, trying to see who are her new team mates. Being too focused on own training, she wasn't able to tell who are they by just their names.

"Each team has to be in their classroom at 3 o'clock. You'll meet your new sensei, a Jounin, there." the teacher continued, staring at them with a mix of pride and longing already. Kawayui sighed.

"Anything else, sensei? Or we're free until 3?" she asked.

"No, that's all, you're free. Just make sure you do good as a Genin!"

She nodded and stood up to go.

"Hey! Kurama!"

She turned her head to see who dared to yell at her like that. She was the only of the Kurama clan in the class, which means it was all up to her to defend the clan's honour.

"Kurama, don't think that only being in my team makes you my friend. You're such a weakling you should never be let in the Academy and I'm going to prove it! You're not use!" as the black haired boy was speaking, Kawayui faced the door again and moulded some chakra, then replaced herself with a plant standing next to the door.

"May I ask you, whoever you are, why are you talking to a plant?"

The class started to laugh at that boy and he became all red, while Kawayui was already gone. Several hours until the meeting with her sensei were used for some more chakra control training, as well as the Bunshin no Jutsu, which she still wasn't good enough in for herself, being able to make only up to 15 clones at once. The aim was 20, as a few years older boy named Hatake Kakashi did when he graduated. graduated ten years ago.

"No way I'm going to be less efficient than a five-year-old kiddie in a genjutsu, it'll be like, a joke, me, one of Kurama clan..." she whispered and then moulded the chakra. "Bunshin no Jutsu!"

Sixteen clones appeared around her.

"Getting better. But that's too much of my chakra, what means I should train in building up my chakra amounts, not jutsus." she thought and immediately started to do push-ups, not really knowing she was watched...

"So, where's that kunoichi, what was her name again... Kawayui Kurama?" a boy with dark, brown hair sighed, lying down on the desk. He closed his dark eyes and poked his forehead protector for fun.

"Dunno, but I hope she won't come, she's useless." answered his comrade angrily, kicking a chair.

"Yeah, I saw how you told it to that plant. Get over it, Yasu, she tricked you, what means she's not so bad." the boy yawned. "I told you, we shouldn't be here, like, a quarter before the time, I'm already bored and I bet sensei's gonna talk for over half a hour some boring crap so I'll probably fall asleep anyway..."

"Shut up, Kohaku, I hear steps." the boy called Yasu stopped his friends monologue.

"Could it be sensei? Or is it Kawayui?" Kohaku asked, getting up and waking up a bit.

"How can I know?"

"Geez, stop being so nervous, I just asked..." he said and then dropped again on the desk. In the same moment, the doorpanel moved, showing a high, white-haired ninja. He came into and right after him Kawayui Kurama did so.

"Yo." he said. "I'm your sensei, it seems" he looked up and down the boys. "Who are you anyway?"

Kohaku stood up.

"I'm Kohaku Nara, from the Nara clan. I was the best pupil in the class!"

"And I'm Yasu Dokkai. And that -" he pointed at Kawayui " - is the Crap Ninja"

Kawayui raised her brow in a "huh?" gesture, but didn't say anything.

"I've met her already on my way here. I'm Kakashi Hatake and, well, you're my first group. I assume that those forehead protectors mean you all have some brain under them, so let's omit all that educative things and get to the things you're interested in. Like, how to become a full-time Genin."

"Huh? Aren't we Genins already?" asked Kohaku, fully surprised. "We DID pass the exams, didn't we..."

"Nope, not at all. I'd barely call you a ninja. The exams showed you're skilled enough to become a Genin, and my first duty is to check if you are able to ever become a shinobi."

"So, how you're going to test that, Hatake-sensei?" asked Kawayui.

"Don't call me like that." he groaned, rolled his eyes and answered. "Tomorrow at 10 o'clock, at the bridge, with all the shinobi gear you have and use. And don't eat your breakfast, seriously. But I don't think any of you will pass. Only about 1/3 of all graduates will get over it..."

"Don't think like that about us, Kakashi-sensei! We're pretty good as for graduates, aren't we, Kohaku? Well, almost all of us." shouted Yasu, looking at Kawayui. She again raised her eyebrow.

"And that's why I don't think you'll pass. Bye for now." Kakashi-sensei headed for the door.

"Wait, that's all? We're free?" Kohaku was surprised.

"Yeah, until tomorrow. I've got some better things to do than bother with you. If you're able to complete the mission, then I'll have any interest in you."

"Fine with me. Kohaku, you going? My mom baked some cookies, we've got to get some strength before tomorrow." Yasu was already in the corridor.

"Sure. Cookies and a game of Shougi!" the boy ran after his friend and Kakashi Hatake followed them slowly. Kawayui stayed in the classroom.

"Nara clan, the smart ones, and being friends with that Yasu guy? You've gotta be kidding me..." she'd say to herself. "But sensei is... pretty hot, even in that mask of his. He reminds me that boy who graduated at age of 5, I wonder if it's him. He doesn't look way older than us and is a Jounin already..."

She smiled to herself and exited the room, just to find sensei several steps from the door, in the radius in which he could've overheard what she said. Kawayui was immobilized by the thought he'd hear her calling him "hot", but then gathered the pieces of her mind and instantly jumped back at high speed, to exit the building by the window and get down by roofs.

Kakashi only smiled under his mask and walked forward through the corridor.

"... So okay, here's the deal. See these bells? You have to get them. See this clock? When it rings, and that will be at 12, we end. If any of you fails, he or she gets to be tied to one of those logs and to watch me eat lunch, plus doesn't get any lunch at all. Anyone who ends up like that goes back to Academy for a bonus year as a punishment. Got it?"

They nodded.

"There are only two bells." Kohaku seemed unconvinced.

"Yes, so?"

"There are three of us."

"You do the math, Kohaku." Kakashi-sensei turned back and did a few steps, so he was the same distance from everyone. "You are allowed to use any technique you know and any weapon you have, including sharp objects like shuriken or kunai. Not being prepared to kill me for the sake of the mission is an auto-fail."

"One question, sensei." Kawayui began, for the first time that day. "You told us not to eat, so we were hungry while doing the test AND so the perspective of not getting a lunch was scarier, right?"

"Point for you, Kawayui."

She nodded.

"The test has started?"

As Kakashi-sensei confirmed, she already wasn't there. Hidden in the trees, she watched the rest of her "team" look at each other without belief and then also hiding in the bushes.

"He's a Jounin... We are merely Genins. Is it even possible for us to get our hand on those darn bells? Will he go easy on us?" she was thinking, while Yasu already attacked. He charged out of the bushes on sensei's right side and while screaming "Bushin no jutsu!", tried to punch him. Kakashi-sensei was faster, countering the hit with his own. But then Yasu poofed - it was just an illusion. The real one attacked from behind, but as his kick reached sensei, he also puffed, leaving Yasu with a log.

"You have to be smarter than that if you want to get me, Yasu" said Kakashi-sensei, appearing to be a few steps further to the memorial stone.

But Yasu didn't stop. He apparently had lots of chakra, because he attacked constantly, using the clone technique all the time. And he constantly missed.

Kakashi-sensei didn't even sweat, evading gently his charges, kicks, punches, kunais, shurikens and clones.

"Or he's waiting for us to come up with something more effective than the standard ninja skills, or he's not going to go easy." Kawayui moved to another tree, so she wasn't seen, but could watch the situation. "And it's already half past ten. I need to do something!"

Then, after another time Yasu being log'd by sensei's Kawarimi no Jutsu, something happened. It was Kohaku.

He appeared from the bushes and his shadow started to move rapidly, aiming at Kakashi-sensei's back while he was occupied with dodging Yasu. Sensei didn't seem to sense the danger from behind...

"Yatta!" screamed Kohaku, walking to his victim, which did the same steps. "I knew that the Kage Mane no Jutsu will come in handy one day"

Kawayui's eyes opened widely. If he immobilized sensei, it means sensei can do nothing to defend the bells he's got. And Kohaku will surely give one of them to Yasu.

Then she'll lose.

"NO WAY!" Kawayui jumped at Kohaku, making both him and sensei fall on the ground. That made her realise something, yet it was already too late to do anything about it - sensei puffed, leaving the three of them with a feeling of failure, a failure they were, attacking an illusion.

But yet, that made Yasu go berserk. He wanted to rip Kawayui into pieces, but happily wasn't able to, as she hid herself as quick as she appeared.

Yet it wasn't enough. It seemed Kakashi-sensei was up to some more things than just evading their attacks - he set up traps. And for goodness sake, he set them on the trees!

"But... how? When?" she asked herself, trying to get out of the net she was caught into, but it wasn't so easy.

So did Yasu, only he was hanging on a tree branch, upside down, tied to it for his own leg. Only Kohaku managed not to get in trouble, as he foresaw the trapping coming. But even if he did see Kakashi-sensei coming, he wasn't good enough to stop what sensei did to him. He got into a genjutsu, and the last thing Yasu and Kawayui heard from his position was his high-pitched scream and a flat "bam!" sound when Kohaku's body fell on the ground.

When Kawayui aimed Kakashi-sensei again, it was only an hour from the deadline. Yasu still was immobilized, but he was on a good way to escaping, and Kohaku managed to use the release technique, Kai no Justu, and come back into the game again.

She was sure it's Kakashi-sensei who's she seeing, no illusion would crumple grass. Now only to make sure she won't be kawarimi'd...

"Maybe an genjutsu would do? No. Yasu tried that. So how? I'd have to be my own clone... That's it!" as soon as she got the idea, she changed her position and when she saw sensei putting off his guard, she used Bunshin no Jutsu.

While some of her clones attacked sensei to make it look like diversion, another clone wanted to get the bells. When Kakashi-sensei dodged that, he was right in the hands of another clone. When they touched themselves, both of them poofed.

It was Kawayui's time to attack.. She aimed sensei and threw a kunai along with some clones, which showed it was only an illusion. Same was with another one. Then, when she was sure it's the real one, she did the same as a while ago, only she was among her clones. She was sure it was a perfect plan.

But it failed too.

"Quite a good strategy there, Kurama, yet not good enough to trick a Jounin." she heard from he back as soon as the bell poofed in her hand.

She disappeared as quickly as she came out of the shadows.

"What's wrong with this test, anyway?! We can't match with him, we're too weak!" she thought, once again hiding in the leaves. And it was only 30 minutes until noon. Only few fierce Yasu's attacks and Kohaku's diversions and traps were made, plus Kawayui trying to cut the strings tied to the bells with kunai, so they'd fall and she could get them. But none of them succeeded.

As the clock rung, sensei ordered them to get out of their hiding spots. She was the last one to get out, still hoping it was all a joke and they did well.

But they didn't.

"You all are morons." started Kakashi-sensei, looking at them, with their stomach's growling for food. He had his lunch, but he didn't eat it, not even intending to do so, as his mask was

still on. "You, Kawayui, and you, Yasu, the most. Who the heck told you to attack your own teammate, girl? And you, not much better, charging like that at me all the time. It was no use and you continued" he sighed. "You did best, Kohaku, yet you still failed. You were thinking, but that wasn't enough to get these bells, plus, you didn't help Yasu even though he is your friend."

Kawayui and Yasu groaned, insulted with the thought they could be friends.

"What this test was about is TEAMWORK. Wanna me spell it? You're a three man band. If you want to do the mission on your own, you will fail. There are three of you for a reason. Teamwork is what a Genin should have in his blood and heart. If not, he will die."

"Okay, I got it, but it was HER who attacked Kohaku!" Yasu yelled at sensei.

"Yeah, well, you'd do it too if you were in my place back then! I was the one loosing!" answered Kawayui, only making Kohaku sigh.

"I'm telling you this because you don't get it. You think you get it, which is not the same as actually getting it. Get it?" Kakashi gnarled at them.

"The lacking bell was to make us individuals, forgetting about the ninja squad we truly are, wasn't it?" Kohaku asked.

"Yes. When you get it, you won't be mad at me failing you, won't you?"

"I probably will be a little bit down, sensei, yet I get it. Next year I'm going to try harder! We're going to try harder!"

Yasu and Kawayui looked at each other and after a while, nodded. It was a pact - no more war, so they're going to really graduate...

Kakashi smiled and disappeared, or that was what they were thinking.

The next year was full of exercise and training. All three of them were trying to get better, and they were trying to get better as a team too. Even if Yasu still wasn't Kawayu's best friend, they never ever let themselves down on a mission.

But it wasn't good enough. Still being an Academy student, they were divided into squads by their marks. And after all that training and getting more powerful, all of them ended with some two rookies rather than themselves. If they stayed together, it would be possible they'd be the strongest Genin team around, and the squads were supposed to present an equal strength.

Kohaku, Yasu and Kawayui knew that thing like this could happen, but they hoped it will not. Yet, they were proud of being able to work as a team, which meant that nothing is impossible when it comes to the way of shinobi - even surpassing a feeling of hate. Yet, it was time for them to say a solid good-bye and go own way. And so they did.

Then it came to the day when they, after passing the final exams at the Academy again, were to meet their new teachers.

Kawayui entered the class and looked upon her new teammates. A Hyuuga, that was sure, he had the characteristic white eyes. And a Inuzuka girl, a wolf puppy by her and the marks on her cheeks were just too obvious.

"Yo." said Kawayui before anyone could say something. "I'm Kawayui Kurama and as you might know, I'm for another year here. Last time I was failed by my sensei, who was-"

"Me."

Kawayui turned around, just to see Kakashi-sensei in the door.

"I was her sensei last time and it seems I'm going to be this time too. How are things going, Kawayui?" he asked, seeming to have a great deal of fun watching her being petrified and staring at him.

"No. Please, no. I really want to become a Genin." she whispered. He giggled, which was fairly odd.

"With that attitude you're never going to. But, we have some young rookies here who would like to know what is going on." Kakashi-sensei pointed at the two and continued. "I'm Kakashi Hatake, your sensei. Who are you?"

For few seconds, they didn't answer, surprised by the conversation they just heard. Then, the Hyuuga one started to talk.

"Shinji Hyuuga, from the Branch Family."

"Okay, and you?" Kakashi-sensei faced the Inuzuka one.

"I..." the puppy barked at Kakashi, running around his master. "I am... My name is Rakki Inuzuka. And... And this is Fuji" she patted the wolf cub. Kakashi nodded and was about to start his speech, when he was interrupted.

"Sensei, is everything same as last year?" Kawayui asked. He looked at her and smiled again, looking even weirder with each second.

"Well, sort of."

"Then may I just go home?"

"Yeah, sure. I'll tell them." Kakashi-sensei shrugged, moving from the door. She rushed out of the room and didn't stop running for about half an hour, circling around the Konohagakure no Sato. Then, she headed for the Academy again, jumping from one roof to another, trying to use her anger and disappointment as physical energy. When she came down on the Academy's square, she'd bump into Kohaku, who just ended his meeting with new sensei.

"Hey, Kawayui-chan, how are you?" he asked, looking at her angry face. "Something happened?"

"Yeah, a big something. Kakashi's my sensei."

"NO WAY!" screamed Yasu, appearing from somewhere in no time. "What are you going to do, then?"

"I think I'll just wait for my new team to come out and try to tell them about it."

"Wouldn't that be against the rules?" Kohaku asked, not sure. "I know I'm going to have some kind of test too, but I didn't tell my teammates, they have to pass it on their own too..."

"Even if it's illegal, I don't care. I'm going to graduate this time." she continued, ignoring Kohaku's careful look.

How wrong she was... How unaware...

"You want us to believe that? It sounds SO wicked, that even if you're saying the truth about the bells, I'm not going to risk my graduation for your freaky, desperate want to become a Genin. Man, you're really obvious." Shinji looked at her like at a total idiot. Rakki looked down on her cub, not answering. Kawayui wasn't even sure if she was listening.

"But I don't lie! Why won't you believe me..."

"'Cause you're a Kurama. You're probably using genjutsu right now, so we were fooled." he continued, and then, like to emphasize what he said, he used the Kai no Jutsu.

That hit the berserk button.

"You evil, spoiled little...!" Kawayui started, but realised that what she was going to do will surely make her fail all the way, so she took ten deep breaths. "You'll see. And when you see, you're going to help me, I assure you."

Yet again, she was wrong. She didn't calculate the Hyuuga pride into it, so even when Shinji realised it's impossible to get these bells alone, he didn't cooperate with neither Kawayui or Rakki. He tried to hit sensei with the Hyuuga style for over 4 hours, while the girls just watched. Firstly, when Shinji was obviously losing, Kawayui tried to help him. When he was attacking, she was there to grab the bells (which never went good, half because of Hatake's ability to dodge her perfectly, half because Shinji wasn't helping too, attacking her once in a while). When he was being hit – she'd catch him (and get some swears and damns in the face). When sensei tried to put him off guard, she was there to distract Kakashi and give Shinji some time to get over it. But it was still no use – without Rakki doing anything and with Shinji trying to knock Kawayui out for „getting in the way" - they couldn't even get close to the mission's goal.

And then the clock's alarm rang.

"I know, I know, sensei. I failed. I'll go die somewhere and we'll probably meet next year, so you can fail me again!" Kawayui shouted angrily. "Just give us the lecture, starve us today and I'll start preparing for next year's exams."

"There, there, Kawayui. Calm down and listen." he answered, but still tied them to the logs. "You were doing fairly good today, not attacking any team mate. Last year you'd

probably punch Rakki unconscious if you knew about the real mission. What leads to another of you – Rakki, for Hokage's sake, you're a ninja. Standing like that in front of your opponent, not even hiding yourself and not helping your team mates... Did you sleep all the time in the Academy? Didn't you learn anything? You, Shinji, weren't any better. To be honest, you acted quite like Kawayui last time. Just don't do it again. She told you all about this exam and now you probably all know – you fail. See you."

Shinji looked him leaving them like he wanted to kill him, but then sighed.

"He's right. I'm sorry"

And those were the last words he said that day.

"I'll... I'll get better!" Rakki declared. Fuji barked as a sign of approval. Kawayui smiled as the sun was setting behind the horizon. She was just hoping that this time, her and her team's work won't go for nothing.

But it did.

Everybody laughed at their team. Kurama who couldn't graduate for two years and Hyuuga and Inuzuka who were left in for a year. Everybody thought they were lame, but there was nobody among the team to show it wrong. Because a good ninja never shows their strength if not necessary.

They were training hard, yet setting the exams marks so they were still having chances to be a team. They co-operated with Kohaku's and Yasu's teams, having a sparring once a week or two, so they were all fit. Friendship bloomed, Shiji left his stupid pride behind, Rakki got some courage. It was going just perfectly.

And they waited like that for the year's end.

Then the exams came.

Once again, young minds showed themselves better than old ones – their scores fitted perfectly and they stayed as a team. It was just the last test to get over. Expecting to see Hatake-sensei again, how surprised they were when some other Jounin came. They did the test perfectly, as he judged them less harshly.

Yet their ambition was never satisfied – an ambition to get those darn Kakashi's bells!

They started their Genin life and quickly forgot about it - missions, spying, becoming a Chuunin... Their ninja lives were rolling on, not bothered by some stupid bells.

"Until today." Kawayui whispered. "But maybe... Just maybe... well, we have holidays. No missions, so we can provide us our own..."

"Seconded." Shinji interrupted her, appearing around. "You met Hatake today too, didn't you?"

"Yeah. You too, Rakki?" she turned around, looking down, under the trees they were standing on.

"Yes, Kawayui. I have met Hatake Kakashi-sensei too today." she answered. Kawayui and Shinji jumped down and they all sat on the grass. Fuji put his head on Shinji's legs to get patted.

"So, shall we begin to think out the mission to retrieve some shiny little, round, sound-making objects?" the boy asked.

"Not here. Trees might have shadows."

"True. So where?"

"Where no shadows are seen in the time no shadows are present, after three ramens." Kawayui set the date. After so many years of working together, they all could understand the code others used.

"So we will meet there. Until then, we gather mirrors."

Rakki stood up slowly, not saying anything and started to walk her way to home. Shinji did so also after waiting a while, so they were not accused of meeting each other

Kurama yawned and waited her time there too. At noon, in the largest plain they knew, so no ninja could sneak up and overhear them, three days from then. They'll meet and exchange information, those little pieces of mirrors they were to gather, each other different parts of it, each other by different methods.

Then, three days later, the plan was made.

"Every day at dawn Kakashi goes to the K.I.A. memorial stone and though it isn't fair to do so, we are ninjas and we have to to attack him at that moment. His bells must lie somewhere in his house, so that is our target. Kawayui has to create the disguise with a genjutsu, Rakki and Fuji are responsible of keeping Hatake's nin-dogs occupied and I am to find the bells with my Byakugan and watch if Kakashi's isn't coming back. After setting the genjutsu, Kawayui goes into the house and gets the bells. You're best at avoiding traps. I'll tell you if I'll see any, yet you're in, not me. After two minutes we withdraw and meet again after a hour, like nothing happened, at the new Ramen bar. Everyone got it?"

Kawayui and Rakki nodded and Shinji smiled, proud of his plan.

"Let's get prepared. Rakki, remember, you can't be recognised."

"I know, Shinji. I am not a kid anymore, you know."

He smiled once more.

"It's hard to believe that both of you aren't fragile, little girls anymore."

"I still am little and fragile to be honest." Kawayui added. They laughed, then suddenly stopped, looked at themselves and left the meeting place.

They saw each other again at dawn. Shinji watched Kakashi leaving home from far away and then gave his mates the signal to start. They all were wearing different than normally clothes and were all perfumed, so the nin-dogs wouldn't have any traits.

Kawayui opened the window and dodged the first trap by a fine somersault. Then, trying to make as little sound as possible and touching the floor as little as possible, she headed for the bedroom. The corridor wasn't big and it looked really plain. And kinda dirty

"I have to make the dirt and dust as it was before I leave..." she thought, entering Hatake's sleeping room.

It wasn't as empty, but still looked even plainer than the corridor. As if Kakashi was barely here. A bed and a wardrobe, a wardrobe open widely and full of ninja suits and several Chuunin jackets. One additional forehead protector was lying on the little table next to the bed. Some books from the "Make Out Paradise" series on the floor. A pair of boxers on the sheets, which were stained in several places.

"Gross." she thought. "I don't think I'll be able to get this out my mind for a year or so."

She looked under the bed and found a box there. She checked it for traps and opened it.

The bells were in there. Little, suprisingly clean, shiny and silver.

"Got'cha."

She grabbed them and put under her clothes so they wouldn't make any sound, put the box back just as it was and started to cover her own traces on the dirty floor.

The dog's barking and growling outside started to fade. Rakki stopped the diversion, the time has ended. It's time to go!

Kawayui closed the door and exited by the same window she came in.

It wen't going good. Too good.

Yet they ended, and a hour later, they were proudly eating their well-earned ramen for breakfast.

"Good job everyone. Let's meet with Kohaku and Yasu if they're in town and tell them. I bet they will be just as happy as we are." Kawayui suggested.

"What a splendid idea! I will send them information by Fuji, we will eat dinner together. Are you fine with that?" Rakki asked.

"Yes. I'll make it, so meet at my house at about eight o'clock. See you then." Shinji said and left them, probably to spend some more time with his longed family.

"I think I will do the same." said the Inuzuka girl, knowing him good enough to see where his steps were heading.

Kawayui watched her go and sighed.

"I wish I had a family too."

She had to do something with herself, and her home needed tidying after several years of their absence, so she stood up and made her way home. And only quiet puffs and little clouds of mist accompanied her in that walk.

It was already late afternoon when she ended cleaning her room, which left her only kitchen and bathroom to go.

She put on her ninja suit some casual clothes, leaving apron in the house and went for Shinji's place. She was looking a little bit odd, in a net suit all over her body and bright shorts, with her right calf and breasts wrapped and in dark, elbow-long gloves with some hand protectors, all covered with a cloak; only her mask stayed home. She also still had kunais with her - the life of a spy taught her that they come in handy in the most unexpected moments. And it was a decent lesson!

Slowly walking along Konoha's alleys, Kawayui enjoyed the sight of all those small lanterns lighting up and increasing evening's sounds, people's voices and rumors.

"So lively, so peaceful, so comforting, so... So home." she whispered, stopping for a while and gazing at all this.

"Yeah, it is, though I'm missing one sound here to call it comforting."

She immediately turned around. He was standing there, with his face behind a book ("What kind of book is that anyway? That *Make Out Paradise*? And he's reading it in public?! I'd never think he's such a pervert..." sprung in Kawayui's mind), like nothing happened.

"You again. Will you stop haunting me, Hatake-sensei?!" she growled at him. He put down the book of his and smiled, which was barely visible.

"I just overheard you talking, so I thought it'll be nice to have a little chit-chat, especially after long time no see. We didn't enjoy that last meeting, did we." he said, doing few steps forward. She did few steps back, to keep the distance. "Oh, look. You don't have your mask on. Why is that? And those casual clothes... A party, isn't it? What are you celebrating? May I come along?"

Kakashi Hatake talking so much wasn't normal. And what he talked was odd, too... Did he realise that his bells are missing? Did he know who stole them?

"I'm in a hurry. Good bye." answered Kawayui, trying to look calm, yet she was worried that their mission failed and she was discovered.

"Oh, you didn't seem so. Can I walk you, wherever you're going?" he did few more steps, overtaking her. It was enough. She knew it, and he probably knew she knew. Mission failed.

Now it's time to run, run like hell.

"No, you can't." she said and immediately did the Shunshin no Jutsu. Little poof was left after her, while she appeared on a roof and started jumping from one house to another. Yet it was no use.

"That wasn't nice." said Kakashi, landing few steps ahead, right in the place at which she was planning to jump again. "You left me again, when I only wanted to talk. To make me forget how impolite you was, you have to do something for me... Let's say, you have to drink tea with me." His voice was shivering with a hidden giggle. And she was shivering with anger. She stopped and that anger was getting stronger with each his word.

"Will you stop haunting me?!" she yelled at him. "Get over it! I graduated, I'm a shinobi, I AM WORTH SOMETHING!"

"It's you and your mates who didn't get over it. Now, give me back the bells and let's have a cup of tea." he poofed, just to emerge next to her. He was holding a kunai near her throat. "Or I'll do it the hard way."

She used Kawarimi no Jutsu to retreat.

"You know, you can't beat me with some E-rank jutsus, which you seem to use all the time, as I watched you." he shouted into the night's darkness, hiding his kunai back into a pocket and looking around. When he spotted Kawayui, she was already ending the hand seal sequence.

At first, she wanted to punch him in the face (or harm him with a decent jutsu, maybe a fire one, probably with some kunais added) for implying that she could only use some Academy tricks, but instead she just showed him she's better - and escaped. Her body shattered into dozens of flower petals, which were blown away with a light wind breeze.

"He knows and he's after me. I stand no chance against him, yet I can't give him the bells back... Shinji would've killed me, and I'd show I'm a coward..." she thought, running through Konoha's streets. She dropped her cloak, so she was less visible, less hearable and more mobile.

"Okay, I admit, that wasn't E-ranked. Yet-" she heard from above a while later. She didn't even look there, she just threw a shuriken there. The voice changed into a quiet poof.

"Using Bunshin no Jutsu, like I was some kind of kid... I'm a Kurama, you idiot! No genjutsu is good against me." her thoughts were even quicker than her legs. "Must've used his ninja dogs with that cloak of mine... He knows my position."

As soon as she thought that she stopped and formed the Rat hand seal.

"Kai!" she whispered. The street changed its look - it's a totally different part of village! She was getting farther and farther from Shinji's place. Kawayui smiled, knowing that losing Hatake won't be so easy. "I might not see you, but I can sense you, bastard."

Using the Bird, Dragon and Rabbit hand seals, she made the wind blow. Listening to its gentle whispers, feeling the leaves and petals it carried, she waited... Then she started again.

"Aimed." she'd whisper, while doing more hand signs. Once one sequence was ended, she immediately started another, not even seeing her target. In a short period of time, several jutsus were cast.

"Playing hide and seek, aren't we?" she asked. "I don't like that game, Hatake-sensei. You will regret starting it too."

With another wind blow, she disappeared, then a rumor was to be heard. A giant tree sprung nearby, just behind Kakashi's back, in the forest near to the village's border.

"I already saw that, Kawayui. " he said, letting the branches to catch him. He looked up, like he was waiting to see his opponent emerging from the trunk, which happened.

The wind was getting stronger, even raising leaves from trees all around.

"I know." said Kawayui and smiled. He still didn't uncover his Sharingan eye, and that let her see a glimpse of surprise in his other eye.

"You don't have any weapon with you. That's.. unexpected. " he declared, obviously having a lot of fun.

"I don't." she answered and did hand seals. " Shikumi no Jutsu ...!"

"You can't paralyze me with a lousy genjutsu. I fear nothing." he said, but she only smiled in response and disappeared in the tree just as she appeared, saying something to him.

A stronger blow tattered their hair and defied her words, as it did with the sound of a flying kunai. Kakashi dodged them with no difficulty even wrapped with the branches, leaving those weapons to dart into the trunk along with some shuriken.

"This gets interesting. Maybe I should try to fight you?" he asked, looking at the place where the kunais were thrown from.

"You shouldn't bother. " Kawayui answered. Kakashi smiled to her. She was standing on a roof with a Hyuuga and an Inuzuka, her teammates.

"Here I am." she continued, jumping down and throwing more weapons at him. This time they hit the target, but it instantly poofed - leaving only a log. The Magen: Jubaku Satsu genjutsu dispelled.

"You're fast." said Kakashi. "But I'm faster." he added, emerging from behind Kawayui's back and putting a kunai to her throat.

"No. I'm clever." she replied and the next thing he caught a glimpse of were the handseals of the Snake, the Dragon, the Hare and the Tiger, and the next thing he heard was the same voice, yet from another place, with Rakki's and Shinji's voices. They all said one thing.

"Katon: Goukakyuu no Jutsu!"

A great burst of flames from three simultaneous jutsus enfolded both Kakashi and Kawayui.

"I'm just a darn clever spy." she added, jumping down and smelling the light breeze, all that was left after her clone which poofed as soon as the jutsu reached it. "Come out wherever you are, I know you dodged that, just as I did."

Kawayui looked around and then jumped down on the ground, as she couldn't find Kakashi. She nodded at her teammates so they would search for him with her. Hyuuga activated his Byakugan, Inuzuka activated her great sense of smell and Kurama listened to the wind, wind that was blowing again.

When they sensed him, it was already too late. Kawayui was drawn into the ground, leaving only her head on the surface.

"You!" she shrieked. "You'll pay for this!"

Her teammates were standing still for few seconds, then charged to attack.

"Ah, calm down, there. Clones beat clones, so we have some time to talk." he said as two of his Kage Bunshin clones emerged from shadows and stabbed the Inuzuka and Hyuuga. They both dispersed into wind blows and then fake Kakashis poofed. "A good one, I'd say. That is your special technique, isn't it? The wind clone jutsu? Quite interesting. Pity I didn't see it with my Sharingan. I almost believed that those transformed clones were really your teammates, but when the Hyuuga couldn't find me with the Byakugan and then charged at me like that... Oh, come on, it's just too obvious."

"It is?" she asked, smiling widely. "My wind clones are obvious... Good to know, Hatake-sensei. "

He raised his eyebrows.

"No..." he started.

"Yeah. All the time." she interrupted.

"No way, I'd see it." Kakashi couldn't believe it.

"You can't see the wind, can you? Nice Shinjuu Zanshu no Jutsu by the way, I sure am less harmful when in the ground." Kawayui's smile was getting wider and wider with each word. "You were attacked by, let me count... at least five clones. And no real person. "

"So the Magen genjutsu was cast by clone, too?" he asked.

"Yes. Also clones did the kunai attack and the fireball jutsu. And, as you said, were transformed into Shinji and Rakki."

"But why?"

"That's a decent question, isn't it? It's already really far, so... Bye Hatake, you bastard. I win." she said and dispersed into a wind blow and some petals and leaves.

"Damn you, Kawayui." Kakashi stood up and did some hand seals, bit his finger and put his hand on the ground. "Kuchiyo no Jutsu!"

In a puff of smoke, a small, brown puppy appeared in that place where Kakashi's hand was a second ago.

"Pakkun, I need you to track down one person."

"It's impossible to find me here, and even if he would find me, he won't get in here that easy." she thought, immersing into the gentle, relaxing waters of hot springs. Transformed into a totally different person, a short-haired, tall blonde, she was sure to be safe. And when her bird came back, but without the bells, she was certain that the trophy is protected too.

"You did good, my friend." she whispered to the falcon which sat on the top of the fence surrounding these hot springs. "You may go back to your home."

It nodded and flew away.

Time passed and Kawayui knew that her friends are worried about her, yet she couldn't let herself be traced by Fuji because there was a chance other nin-dogs will get the smell of her too. But the public baths were the only place Shinji wouldn't look in with his Byakugan (a darn bigot he was!), so after some searches they'd know where she was, not finding her in any other place. So she sat there and waited for Rakki to come to check if their predictions were right.

It didn't last long as the one waited for appeared in the mist, looking around. Yet, Kawayui didn't wave to her to let her know where she was - there still was a chance it was somebody else.

Rakki plunged into the hot water and then screamed because of the heat. Kawayui raised her blonde brow and knew it was time to look out. Rakki loves hotness, but she's too shy and elegant to jump like that into the pool. It certainly wasn't her. Who was it then? There was only one answer...

The (supposed) girl found her (his?) place somewhere in the pool and watched others. Women went in and out, but only Kawayui stayed all the time, albeit moving around and making herself look as a normal women that is just staying longer. She couldn't go out. If it was who she thought it was, he'd have her right in front of his nose.

"Hello there." the Rakki-looking girl said, suddenly appearing next to Kawayui. "The water's really hot today, isn't it?" she asked.

Kawayui nodded, now knowing for sure it wasn't Rakki. She never talks like this.

But, how to escape? She couldn't form a wind clone in the water... Maybe just play for time, gain it till the real Rakki appears and then suddenly raise a scream and uncover the

"pervert"... then, in the jumble, run with Rakki.

Yes, that was a good plan. Well, the best she could invent.

"Yes, it is, it takes some time to get used to it..." she answered.

The girl looked deeply in Kawayui's eyes and smiled.

"You remind me someone. Don't I know you?"

"I don't think so... where from you could know me, miss-...?" Kawayui lowered her head and pretended to be doing something with her hands.

"Dunno... Maybe the Ninja Academy? Weren't you a student?"

"No, no. I'm no ninja. And no, I don't have a twin sister, either." she smiled.

"Yet those look like hand seals." the girl continued. Was she (he!) suspecting her identity? Or just trying to trial her, because she was the first one to suspect, staying so long?

"Oh, no. It's just a nervous tic I have. Are *you* a ninja then?"

"Why, yes! I even have these clan markings, you see? I'm Rakki Inuzuka." she said. Kawayui nodded and answered:

"Ohh... I see. My name's Daisuko Nami. So, you have a puppy, right? I heard the Inuzukas always raise puppies!"

"They do." someone said from the left. They both turned, just to see ANOTHER Rakki standing there, with an angry face expression. "But I do not remember them to have any look-alikes in standard."

A heavy silence hanged in the air. Kawayui looked at one Rakki then another, pretending to be surprised, then she raised a scream.

"PERVERT!"

Each and every eye in the pool turned their way. Kawayui quickly mixed into the crowd, when Rakki slapped the other one's face. A quiet 'poof' and a little cloud revealed the real identity of the person - a tall, white-haired ninja with his face masked and one eye covered. Hatake Kakashi.

All women in the pool simultaneously screamed the same word as Kawayui did a second ago, while she left. When they started to hit Kakashi (or at least try, he's a ninja after all) nobody noticed that the second Rakki disappeared too.

"Dearest Hokage, how I love the Kage Bunshin no Jutsu." whispered Kawayui, quickly putting her clothes on and exiting the hot springs.

"We all love it, don't we." she heard from the up. She stopped and slowly looked at the top of the spring's buildings roof with her eyes widely opened. Kakashi was there.

He jumped down and made few steps forward her.

"Now, come one, don't make it last longer, it's getting a little frustrating and you're just wasting your chakra." he said, pulling out his hand in the gesture of demanding the return of the bells. Kawayui sighed and reached into the pocket of her shorts.

"You're right." she said, taking her closed palm out of the pocket. "I'm wasting chakra, while I've got so many tools!"

A thin string sparkled in her hands while she stretched it and threw at the nearest tree, repeating it to move from one to another at greater speed than any ninja could run.

Kakashi only mumbled something about boredom and followed her. He continued following her until she got to the woods; there, he'd overtake her and just attack.

Kawayui really tried to avoid his attacks, but it was hard. He was stronger and faster (well, he was a Jounin after all) and she couldn't block him if she wanted her bones in one piece (the drawback of being little and thus swift, yet fragile). So it involved many high-speed jumps and bouncing, running on water and trees, hanging from branches and deflecting shuriken with the garrote. All she could attack him with were kunai, which he'd easily reflect on his ANBU-like gloves. Seeing that, she HAD to start using jutsus, even if it meant using up her chakra to the last drop.

Trying not to set the forest on fire (that'd be stupid with her inside) she used some Fire jutsus, along with constantly attacking him with her powerful wind attacks, ramming his weapons back at him and blowing him away from his positions, not leaving him a moment to think or come up with a strategy. It was her last chance to just put him in such a mind-screwed state, that he would put his guard down, giving her a second to land a full-damaging attack.

But it was her to get caught.

Kakashi suddenly appeared near to her with a kunai just at the height of her heart, nailing her to the tree. What is more, it was her own kunai, as if he wanted to show her she's so bad he'll beat her with her own weapon.

They looked into each other's eyes for a moment, and then she quickly used Shunshin no Jutsu, making it out with no scratch, yet Hatake was quick enough to cut through the bandages around her chest. Two little bells fell out and Kakashi smiled, like it was what he wanted to do, like it was just too obvious.

She jumped few trees back and while he took the bells from the branch, she tied the bandaged good.

"See? Told you it's no use." he said, waving the bells.

"Yeah, right." she answered angrily, trying to cover whole her breasts. His eyebrow raised and he looked at the bells. When he moulded chakra and whispered "Kai!", they changed into two wooden marbles connected with a string.

"Good one, but you shouldn't tell me that, should you?" he said, looking at Kawayui again.

"I should." she shouted and jumped to attack him. He yawned and put his guard up to block the coming fist. he didn't expect to be attacked from the back. And from both sides.

Looking around, he saw three more Kawayuis, who all landed a clear hit on him. Although it was a little too late, he kawarimi'd away. All of them jumped back and started to look around, searching for him in the swastika formation.

"Impressive, I must say. Still being able to do Kage Bunshin. I wouldn't expect you to have that much chakra. " he admitted, appearing on a higher branch on that tree. "I think it's time to give it a try and just end it in that case." he added and reached to his covered eye. When he opened his Sharingan, he laughed. "Oh, I see. Then, I call it back. Your chakra amount isn't impressive at all, yet your teamwork may count as good."

The four Kawayuis smiled and three of them got covered in a poof of smoke. As it cleared, Shinji, Rakki and Fuji appeared, while Kakashi hid himself again.

"Sorry it took so long, Kawayui-chan. It was hard to find you." Shinji said, while moulding his chakra. "Byakugan!"

"No, really? I thought I'm a damn highly-visible ninja with all my spying techniques!" she answered angrily. Rakki just nodded and activated her strong smell, trying to sense Kakashi with it, just as Fuji did.

Then, after a while, Shinji's eyes widened. He didn't say anything or even do anything. That one act of his eyes was enough for Kawayui.

"KATON: KARYUU ENDAN!" she screamed while doing hand seals, like she wanted to scare away all living things around. Then she took a deep breath and blew a long jet of fire from her mouth.

Meanwhile, Rakki and Fuji ate soldier pills and used the Juujin Bunshin technique. When the flames went down, they both jumped where Shinji aimed them. Like best nin-dogs, they captured surprised Kakashi and didn't let him move, while Kawayui proceeded to cast another jutsu.

Great vines started to sprout from the ground and wrap themselves around the trees, higher and higher. When they reached Kakashi, they looked like hungry beasts, wrapping him so tightly that he was almost strangled. Rakki and Fuji jumped away, yet still staying near to catch him if he managed to escape.

"I've got my Sharingan on, using genjutsu is stupid." Kakashi gasped, while being stifled by the bean vines.

"Realising the existence of genjutsu isn't enough to cast it away." said Kawayui, revealed in a bean pod that sprouted right next to him. she had a large kunai in her hand. His kunai. "You're not invincible." she said, putting the kunai to his throat. "Yet it's pity Konoha will loose a ninja like you."

Shinji and Rakki shivered.

"Wait. You really want to kill him?" the Hyuuga asked. "He's from our village after all! it's just... they're just bells!"

"He attacked me. FIRST. I am more than willing, capable and allowed to eliminate the danger. It doesn't matter what village he's from. He poses serious hazards. What if we were Genins? It'd be dangerous! Would he be allowed to fight with us like that and be set loose, just because he's from Konoha?"

"No." Shinji answered, admiring his blunder.

"Good work, Kawayui. You passed!" said Kakashi instead.

"I passed what?" she asked, still having the kunai at his throat.

"This was a test for the Special Jounin rank, Hokage wanted to see if you're good enough to be a spying specialist. And you proved yourself worthy of this title, using wisely many diversion and spying techniques. Congratulations!"

She was silent for few seconds.

"Nice try. Shove that title up your ass, Hatake. You still are hazardous." she whispered. Kakashi opened his eyes widely, while she took the attempt to kill him.

Kawayui swung the kunai, aiming it at his aorta. But nothing happened. A glittery string of chakra was connected to the kunai, stopping it from cutting through the Copy Ninja's neck. Kawayui turned around to see who stopped her and saw the Third Hokage.

"It's enough, Kurama Kawayui. He's telling the truth. Let him go." he said. Kawayui didn't move, even after catching a glimpse of Shinji nodding it's no genjutsu, that it's Hokage as real at it seems. "Now. That's an order." continued Hokage.

Kawayui groaned and let him go slowly. While the bean vines disappeared, leaving him free on the tree branch, she jumped down. The Third wished them a nice day, told Kawayui to see him the next day and disappeared.

The Kurama made few steps, stopped, turned around and again jumped on the tree, landing next to Kakashi. She put his kunai back into his bag without any word.

"Where are the darn bells anyway, then?" he asked.

She looked up at him quietly and smiled after a while, then opened the palm she just took out of his kunai sack. They were there, shining gently.

"You didn't hid them with the Kuchiyose no Jutsu then?" Kakashi surprised.

"I had them with me all the time. Double hinged into wooden marbles. I'm just that clever... Hatake-sensei."

"I told you to not to call me that already." he said, covering his Sharingan.

"You also told me I would never pass the Genin test."

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